

Some 36 million people were persecuted, and up to a million died in the turmoil, which lasted until 1976.

The Great Leap Forward

After creating the Chinese People's Republic in 1949, Mao launched reforms to transform China's semi-feudal, mostly agricultural society into an industrialized socialist state. In the late 1950s, in a bid to achieve rapid economic growth, Mao ordered the Great Leap Forward. Industrial output climbed with steel and coal production, the rail network doubled, and more than half of all Chinese land was irrigated by 1961.

However, this development came at a terrible cost. Mao transformed rural China into a series of farming communes in which villagers pooled land, animals, tools, and crops. The authorities took vast amounts of grain from the communes to feed city workers, and this, along with a series of natural disasters, led to famine and starvation. The consequences were staggering: an estimated 45 million people died.

A new foreign policy

After the Cultural Revolution, Mao needed American expertise to restore China, and the US wanted an ally against the Soviet Union. In 1972, US President Richard Nixon

traveled to Peking to meet with Mao. By the time Mao died in 1976, China had become a major oil producer with nuclear capabilities.

Deng Xiaoping, who led China from 1978 to 1997, was willing to use capitalist ideas to focus on economic growth. But while he initiated new and far-reaching measures, such as inviting foreign firms to invest in Chinese industry and supporting developing technologies, he also resisted pressure to make democratic reforms.

By the beginning of the new millennium, China's economic growth was spectacular. In 2001, the country was admitted to the World Trade Organization, and in 2008 it played host to the Olympic Games in Beijing. Some economists predict that by 2026 China will boast a gross domestic product (GDP) greater than Japan and Western Europe.

After Mao's death, the Chinese Communist Party condemned the Cultural Revolution as a disaster. However, as the country experienced a period of unparalleled economic growth, a sense of nostalgia for Mao's ideals, focused on the people and self-sufficiency, grew among farmers and members of the urban working class. Today, Mao's legacy continues to cast a long shadow over a modernizing China. ■

Mao Zedong



Born in 1893 into a wealthy farming family from Hunan Province, Mao Zedong was the leader of Communist

China from 1949 until his death in 1976. While working as a librarian at Peking University, he became a communist and helped found the Communist Party in 1921. Six years later, after leading an unsuccessful rebellion against nationalist leader Chiang Kai-shek, Mao was forced to retreat to the countryside, where he proclaimed the Chinese Soviet Republic in 1931. He took control of the Communist Party in 1935, after proving his leadership during the Long March, and defeated Chiang

during the civil war of 1945–1949.

A devoted Leninist, Mao became disenchanted with the Soviet policy of “peaceful coexistence” toward the West and developed Maoism, a stronger form of communism. However, his radical ideas and experiments with collectivization led to the death and suffering of millions. One of his last acts, in 1972, was to hold a meeting with Richard Nixon, the first American president ever to visit China.